Game Analysis Report

— A Narrative Deconstruction of the NIA Scenario in *Gakuen Idolmaster*

1. Abstract

Gakuen Idolmaster is a new multimedia project developed by Bandai Namco Entertainment as part of the *Idolmaster* franchise. Its gameplay can be described as an innovative fusion of *Uma Musume: Pretty Derby* and *Slay the Spire*, primarily combining character training and card-based mechanics within an anime-style game.

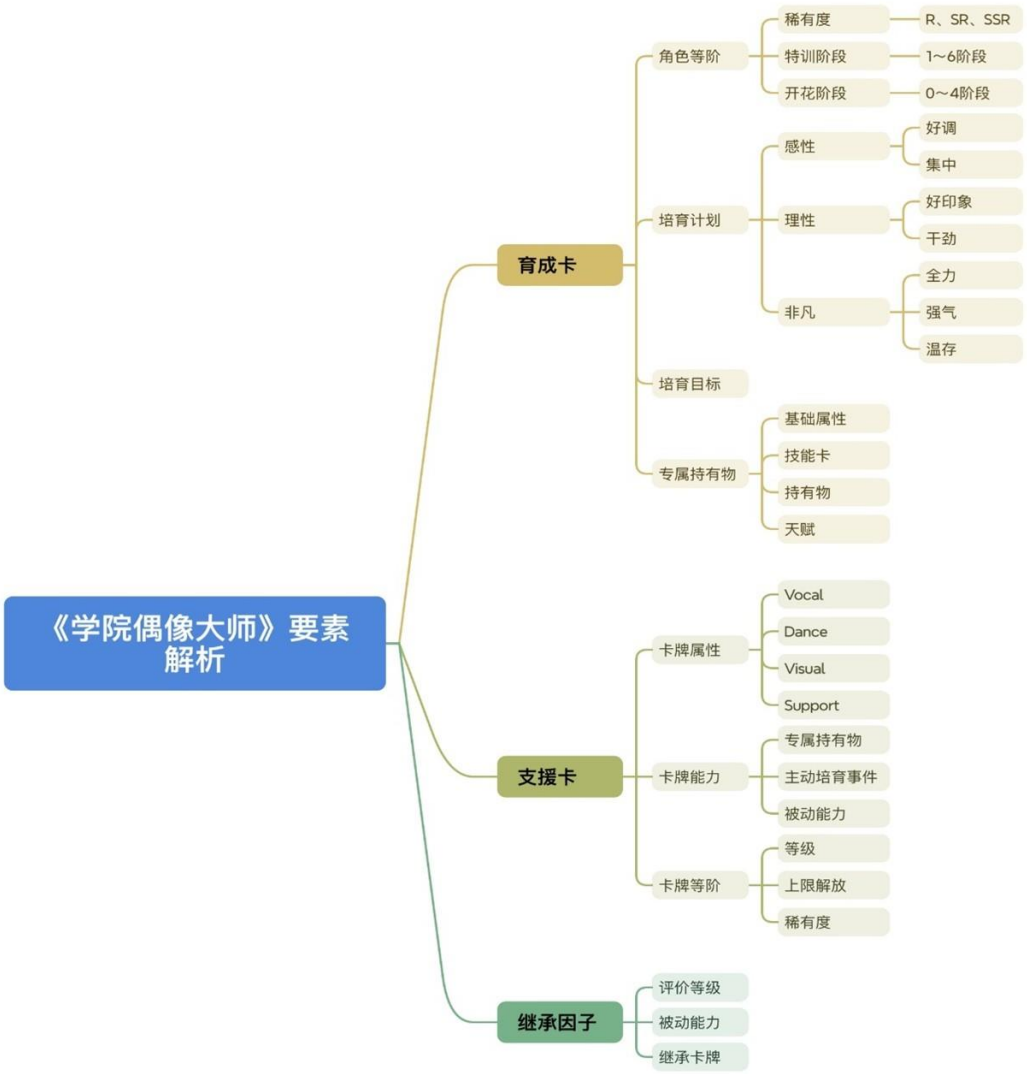
In this game, players select different characters, support cards, and inherited factors, then train their chosen character while progressing through a specific scenario. During this process, players must complete mid-term and final auditions. By improving character attributes and acquiring cards throughout training, players aim to reach sufficient audition scores to pass these challenges and ultimately achieve victory.

In this paper, I will focus on the NIA scenario to deconstruct the game's core gameplay systems and analyze its key strengths.

2. Element Analysis

As a hybrid of two game genres, *Gakuen Idolmaster* features relatively complex character attributes and gameplay systems. In this section, I will break down and analyze the game's core attribute elements. The diagram below provides an

overview of these elements.



At the initial team setup stage, players must select a training card for the run, along with six support cards and four inherited factors. The following section provides a detailed breakdown of these three components:

2.1. Training Card

The training card represents the primary character being developed by the player. Each training card contains several attribute elements, including character training rank, training plan, exclusive items, and base stats.

2.1.1. Exclusive Items and Base Stats

We begin with an analysis of the character's exclusive items and base stats. Taking the character card "Campus Mode!!" Shion Shizuka as an example, as shown in the figure below:

It can be observed that each character possesses four initial core attributes: Vocal, Dance, Visual, and Stamina. Taking this character card as an example, the initial values are Vo.: 100, Da.: 115, Vi.: 90, and Stamina: 33. These four attributes constitute the fundamental components of character development and serve as key indicators of training progress.

Additionally, aside from Stamina, the three main attributes each have different growth rates. In this case, the base growth rates are 9%, 23%, and 23%, respectively. These rates determine the additional gains in attributes acquired during the training process.

2.1.2. Character Rank

Each character card features both a training rank (special training stages) and a "talent bloom" progression system. These function as major meta-progression elements. From the detailed view, it can be seen that these systems enhance the character's base stats and exclusive items, making them persistent, cross-run progression mechanics.

2.1.3. Training Plan

Next, we analyze one of the most important and complex components of the character card: the Training Plan. This system forms a core part of the game's primary gameplay loop.

Training Plans are divided into three main categories with seven subtypes:

- **Emotional**: Good Condition, Focus
- **Rational**: Good Impression, Motivation
- **Extraordinary**: Full Power, High Spirits, Conservation

We will examine each category in detail.

First, the **Emotional type**, which consists of the following two attributes:

- **Good Condition**: Increases card score by 50%, decreases by 1 stack at the end of each turn.
- **Focus**: Increases the base score of cards by 1 per stack; stacks do not decay over turns.

These two attributes are synergistic and can jointly enhance card scoring. When Good Condition stacks are above zero, the scoring formula is:

Actual Card Score = (Base Card Score + Focus Stacks × 1) × (1 + 50%)

Within this category, both attributes function as buffs that amplify card performance rather than directly generating score. Players must still play scoring cards to convert these bonuses into points.

Next, the **Rational type**, which includes:

- **Good Impression**: Grants 1 point per stack at the end of each turn; stacks decrease by 1 each turn.
- **Motivation**: Each stack increases shield gain by +1 whenever shield value is increased.

Unlike the Emotional type, these two attributes have weaker synergy. Good Impression generates points directly through its stacks, while Motivation enhances defensive mechanics and does not directly contribute to scoring.

Finally, the **Extraordinary type**, which consists of three attributes:

- **Full Power**: By accumulating Full Power value, the character enters a Full Power state at 10 stacks. In this state, card usage increases by 1, reserved cards are moved into the hand, and card score gains are increased by 200%. The state lasts for one turn.
- **High Spirits**: When the state indicator is set to High Spirits, it has two stages. In Stage 1, both card score and stamina cost increase by 100%. Using another High Spirits-altering card upgrades it to Stage 2, where score gain increases to 150%.
- **Conservation**: Similarly, this state has two stages. In Stage 1, both card

score and stamina cost are reduced by 50%. Upgrading to Stage 2 reduces both by 75%. Additionally, when the Conservation state ends, the character gains 5 or 8 stacks of Passion for one turn, increasing base card score gains and granting an extra card usage.

Unlike the previous two categories, the Extraordinary type requires players to dynamically switch between these three states. Effective planning of state transitions is essential to maximize scoring potential.

2.2. Support Cards

Next, we analyze the second major component: Support Cards. Support cards are a key means of enhancing the base attributes of character cards. Below is an example of a support card:

Each support card has one base attribute (rarity), two meta-progression attributes (level and limit break), and two categorical attributes (training plan restriction and base attribute type). Training plan restrictions are divided into Emotional, Rational, Extraordinary, and Unrestricted, while base attribute types include Vocal (Vo.), Dance (Da.), Visual (Vi.), and Stamina. These categorical attributes limit the usage scope of support cards, resulting in different support card combinations for each character card and increasing overall build diversity. Taking the example shown above, this support card is an unrestricted Visual (Vi.) support card, with a level of 45, a limit break stage of 1, and an SSR rarity.

At the same time, each support card provides the following enhancement

capabilities:

- One unique item or card;
- Up to two training abilities;
- Up to six passive abilities;

Through passive abilities, support cards provide global stat enhancements to the character. During the training process, randomly triggered support card events allow players to obtain the card's unique item or activate its training abilities. Using the previous example, when specific support card events are triggered, the following effects may be gained:

- Obtain the support card's unique item;
- Increase Visual (Vi.) by 20;
- Enhance a random unenhanced card;

By selecting different combinations of support cards, players can achieve varied attribute enhancements, enabling more effective character development.

2.3. Inherited Factors

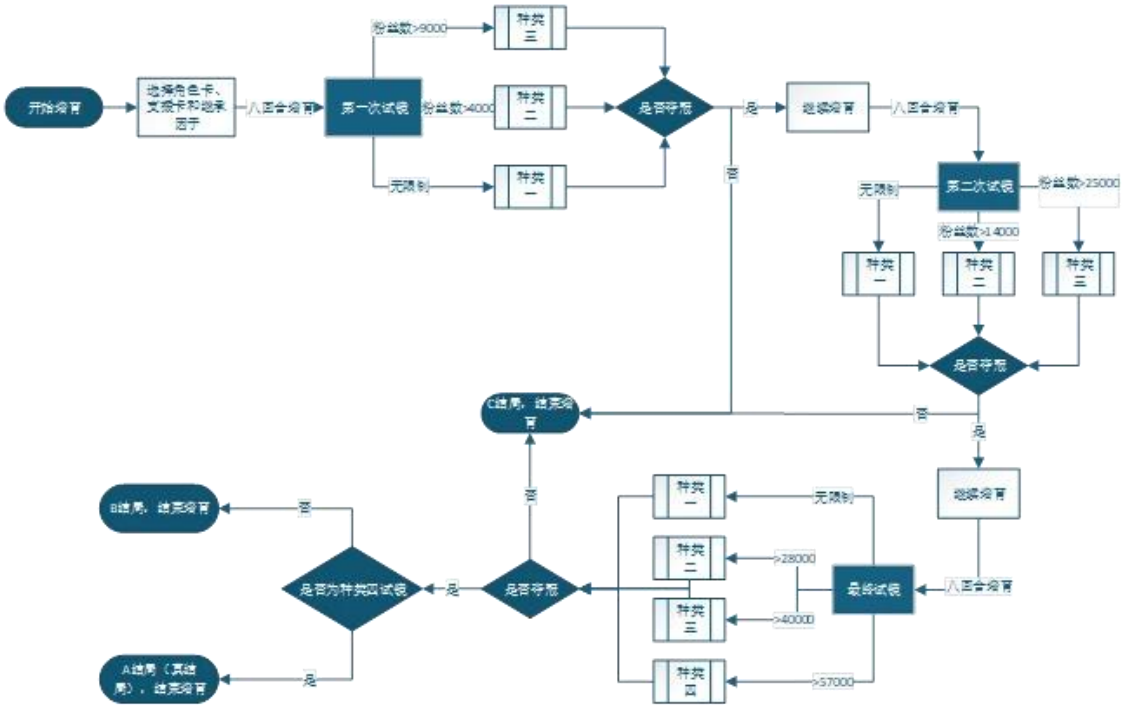
Finally, we examine inherited factors. At the end of each training run, players receive a random inherited factor, as illustrated below:

It can be observed that each inherited factor consists of several components: factor rating, obtainable cards, and training attribute bonuses. Inherited factors serve as a meta-progression system in the game, allowing players to continuously obtain stronger factors through repeated training runs, thereby supporting future character development.

3. Gameplay Analysis

Next, we analyze the core gameplay of the “N.I.A. Scenario.” This scenario features four primary training attributes: Vocal (Vo.), Dance (Da.), Visual (Vi.), and Fan Count; as well as four types of obtainable resources: cards, drinks, P-items, and currency.

During the training process, players enhance these four attributes to strengthen their character while acquiring cards, drinks, and P-items. These resources are then utilized during evaluation phases to generate scores. The gameplay follows the core flow illustrated below:



The following section provides a detailed analysis of the scenario. This scenario consists of a total of 24 training turns and three audition (evaluation) turns. During training turns, players must improve their character and acquire resources such as cards, drinks, and P-items, while aiming to achieve the highest possible score in the interspersed audition turns.

In summary, the scenario can be divided into two main parts: the **Training Phase** and the **Evaluation Phase**, which are analyzed separately below.

First, the **Training Phase**, which mainly consists of the following training options:

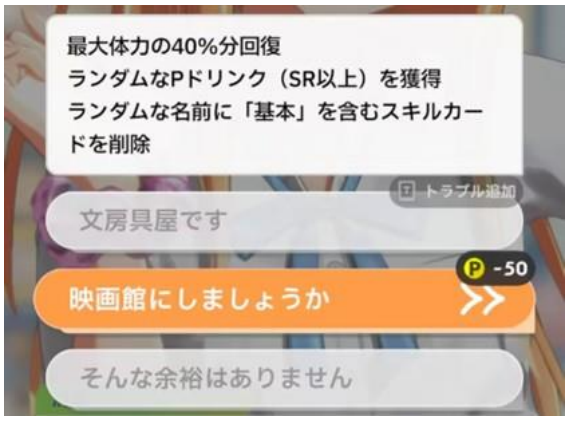
- **Attribute Training**: Players select one of the three core attributes (Vocal, Dance, Visual) to train, consuming stamina to increase the chosen attribute. If an SP Training is triggered, additional attribute gains are granted. The increase in attribute value follows the formula:

Final Gain = Base Gain × (1 + Character Bonus Percentage)

- **Outing**: By spending currency or accepting negative cards, players can choose from three outing options. These may include the following effects:
    1. Restore stamina
    2. Obtain drinks
    3. Remove or transform cards
    4. Enhance cards

In the example shown below, the player may choose:

1. Restore 20% stamina without spending currency and enhance a random card;
2. Spend 40 currency to restore 40% stamina, obtain a random drink, and remove a random basic card;
3. Gain a negative card to restore 60% stamina, obtain two random drinks, and enhance a random card.



It can be observed that in this event, the player's rewards are proportional to their costs—the greater the expenditure, the greater the benefits gained.

- **Shopping**: Players spend currency to purchase cards, drinks, or to enhance or remove cards, as illustrated in the example below:

- **Promotion (Work Activities):** One of the primary ways for players to gain fans. In each promotion event, players choose one of three randomly generated options, obtaining items while increasing the three selected base attributes in subsequent turns, as well as boosting fan count. In the case of a "Great Success," additional fan gains are awarded. An example is shown below:

In this section, the possible options include:

1. Restore stamina, gain 1700 fans, obtain a card, and increase base attributes;
2. No stamina cost, obtain a drink, gain 2400 fans, obtain a card, and increase base attributes;
3. Consume 5 stamina, gain 2400 fans, obtain an enhanced card, and increase base attributes;
4. Consume 5 stamina, obtain currency, gain 2400 fans, obtain a card, and increase base attributes;

- **Special Guidance**: By spending currency, players can further specialize and enhance already upgraded cards, selectively gaining additional card value improvements. Each guidance session allows only one card to be enhanced.

Next, we analyze the **Evaluation (Audition) Phase**. Auditions serve as the game's assessment stages, where players select an appropriate difficulty based on their character development and fan count, aiming to achieve sufficient scores to pass. The figure below shows the three options available in the first

audition:

In each audition, the options increase in difficulty from bottom to top, with progressively higher requirements and correspondingly greater rewards. Taking the first audition as an example, if we select the highest difficulty option, we enter the following audition interface:

In this stage, the interface consists of the following elements: turn countdown, status bar, item bar, conditional bonus bar, stamina, hand area, and ranking score. Each is explained below:

- **Turn Countdown**: Located at the top-left of the screen, displaying the remaining turns, the corresponding evaluation attribute, and its score multiplier;
- **Ranking Score**: Located at the top-right, showing the current ranking and each competitor's score;

- **Status Bar**: Located on the left side, displaying the current buffs and debuffs applied to the character;
- **Conditional Bonus Bar**: Located at the top-left, indicating conditions that, if met before a specified turn, grant bonuses in that turn;
- **Item Bar**: Includes the drink bar at the bottom-left and the P-item bar on the right. Drinks can be used at any time, take effect immediately, and do not consume turns; the P-item bar functions as a status tracker, showing acquired items and their remaining activations;
- **Hand Area**: Located at the center, displaying playable cards. Players can choose to play cards or skip the turn to recover stamina;
- **Stamina**: Located at the top-right, showing the character's remaining stamina and shield value.

During the evaluation phase, players must plan their card usage order based on turn limits and turn-based bonuses, while strategically using drink items to maximize buffs and achieve the highest possible score, ultimately securing first place to win.

Each training run includes three auditions. Successfully passing an audition grants attribute growth based on the score achieved in each category, as well as a large number of fans based on the total score. If the player fails to secure first place in any audition, the run ends in failure, resulting in a C ending. Passing the final audition at one of the lower three difficulty options results in a successful training and a B ending. Clearing the highest difficulty of the final audition grants success

and unlocks the A ending (true ending).

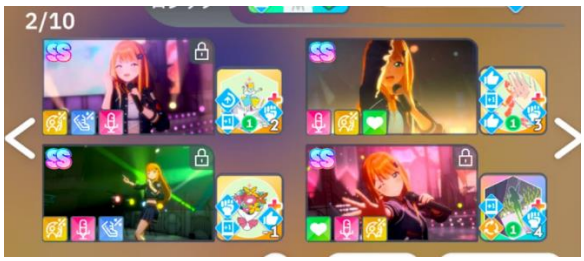
4. “Deck-Thinning Build” — A Mainstream Playstyle Example

After analyzing the core elements of the N.I.A. scenario, we now examine how the game is played in practice through a representative mainstream strategy. Using the character card “Campus Mode!!” Shion Shizuka as an example, we will analyze the gameplay logic of this build.

In the game, cards are divided into three types: A cards (Action/Scoring cards), M cards (Mental/Buff cards), and T cards (Negative cards). Additionally, each card is categorized as either reusable or single-use. This leads to the core idea of this strategy: **deck thinning**.

In this playstyle, players remove reusable cards from their deck through outing events, shopping, or random support card events, or convert them into single-use cards. Meanwhile, only a few key reusable scoring cards are retained, allowing players to concentrate their scoring potential during evaluation phases.

Using the aforementioned character card as an example, for a Good Impression-type character, the core setup includes three primary cycling cards and one key buff card:



During gameplay, the player’s primary objective is to remove the initial reusable basic cards from the deck as quickly as possible through outing options. At the

same time, when drawing cards, players should aim to obtain the core cards mentioned above (or acquire them directly through inherited factors, which significantly reduces early-game pressure). Additionally, when acquiring new cards, players should prioritize single-use cards to avoid disrupting the late-game deck cycle.

During the audition phase, players must prioritize playing all single-use cards and buff cards as early as possible based on the draw order. Once these cards are exhausted, only three key cycling cards remain in the deck. The faster this cycle is established, the more turns can be looped, resulting in higher overall scores.

5. Analysis of Strong Design Mechanics

After analyzing the structural elements and core gameplay of the N.I.A. scenario, we now examine the rationale behind its design and evaluate its strengths and weaknesses.

Drawing inspiration from *Uma Musume: Pretty Derby* and *Slay the Spire*, *Gakuen Idolmaster* successfully integrates and innovates upon the mechanics of both games. As a character-training card game with light roguelike elements, it features relatively complex gameplay systems.

5.1. Sense of Achievement and Player Experience

In terms of character development, *Gakuen Idolmaster* adopts a system similar to *Uma Musume: Pretty Derby*, where players start from scratch to train a character, improving levels, star ratings, and affinity, while continuously acquiring memory cards (inherited factors) for future runs. This system functions as cumulative meta-

progression, where each run contributes to long-term growth rather than existing as an isolated experience. It effectively provides players with a strong sense of achievement, as the training process becomes a journey of witnessing character growth.

However, unlike *Uma Musume: Pretty Derby*, *Gakuen Idolmaster* introduces a card-based system. In *Uma Musume*, players must manage up to five attributes, creating significant pressure, while outcomes rely heavily on randomness rather than player input—often resulting in frustrating experiences, such as failed training despite high success rates or unused skills during races.

In contrast, *Gakuen Idolmaster* reduces the primary attributes to three and replaces pure randomness with a card-based scoring system. This change lowers the burden of training while making performance more dependent on player decision-making. As a result, players gain a stronger sense of control and engagement, as well as a platform to demonstrate their strategic understanding and skill. This fusion and innovation of mechanics is, in my view, one of the game's most compelling features.

5.2. Differences and Interconnections Between Branches

In the game, character training plans are divided into three main categories with seven subtypes. While the major categories do not overlap in functionality, the subtypes within each category are internally interconnected.

When playing, different training plans lead to fundamentally different deck compositions and playstyles. The diversity of training plans and card types

provides players with varied gameplay experiences, encouraging them to experiment with different combinations and strategies. This design enhances replayability and extends playtime.

Within each category, sub-branches are not entirely independent. For example, in the Emotional category, Good Condition and Focus must work together to maximize card scoring, and players may even pursue enhanced states like “Excellent Condition” for further gains.

In the Rational category, Good Impression and Motivation may appear unrelated, but their corresponding cards often interact. For instance, the card “Dreamland” requires consuming Good Impression stacks to activate, while granting Motivation stacks. This design challenges players to balance both subtypes, explore optimal scoring efficiency, and consider deck composition more deeply, thereby increasing gameplay depth and enjoyment.

Finally, the recently introduced Extraordinary category demonstrates even stronger interconnectivity. Unlike the previous categories, its three subtypes are no longer independent but instead function as a unified system governed by a state pointer. The character’s state continuously shifts among the three modes, forming an integrated mechanic. In this system, players must carefully plan deck composition and card sequencing, managing transitions between High Spirits and Conservation states while accumulating Full Power to enter the optimal burst window during auditions.

Overall, the design of training plans significantly enhances gameplay depth,

offering diverse playstyles and a broader decision space. This variety reduces player fatigue and contributes to longer engagement and a more satisfying experience.

From a game design perspective, this highlights an important principle: game elements should not be designed in isolation. Instead, designers should emphasize the relationships between systems, using their interactions to create emergent possibilities and richer gameplay.

5.3. Achievement and Ranking Systems

The game includes character-specific achievement systems and leaderboards based on final scores. This is a common design approach that provides players with clear goals and challenges. Achievements and rankings motivate players to strive for higher performance while offering competitive players and completionists a platform to pursue mastery and recognition, greatly enhancing engagement.

5.4. Randomness in Light Roguelike Design

Randomness is introduced throughout the training process, including card draws, support card triggers, training success events, event choices, and audition conditions.

The inclusion of these random elements increases uncertainty and adds excitement to each run, while also testing the player's adaptability when outcomes are less favorable.

6. Shortcomings in Game Design

Despite its many strengths, *Gakuen Idolmaster* also has notable design shortcomings.

- In terms of gameplay, there is currently a dominant strategy—the "deck-thinning build." This leads to a lack of diversity in late-game play, as most character builds converge on the same approach: removing reusable cards and constructing a minimal cycling deck. Additionally, within each training plan, only a few cards are truly effective for scoring and buffs, while many others have little practical value and are largely ignored by players. This limitation in viable strategies and useful cards significantly reduces replayability and restricts player creativity.
- The game also suffers from slow progression. Players gain relatively few resources after each run, making it difficult to quickly develop new characters. Furthermore, many cards are unlocked through account level progression, and some of the most useful cards require very high levels. As a result, players may struggle to achieve high scores in the early stages and must invest significant time before accessing new content, which can diminish long-term engagement.